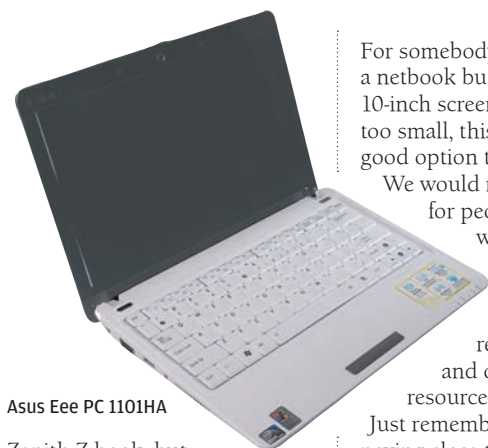


Eee keyboard

The Eee Keyboard is a PC-in-a-keyboard with an Atom processor, an SSD, 5-inch, 800 x 480 pixel touchscreen display, and wireless HDMI

Jolicloud

Cloud-based OS in the making for netbooks



Asus Eee PC 1101HA

Zenith Z-book, but in real-life, we didn't notice a lag when running basic applications. But a two-hour long 720p Hi-def movie file lagged a lot during playback. Even though Asus advertises its "HD" display so profusely, we consider that this machine is not suitable for watching HD videos.

A low-powered processor is bound to have a positive impact on the battery life, and we measured an astounding figure of close to seven hours in our battery drain test. Thus, if used under light-load, it could very well last you more than eight hours. The web cam quality is again similar to previous Asus Eee PC models; i.e. decent. Quake 3 refused to run on this machine. Thus we couldn't measure its fps score.

At Rs. 26,000, the pricing for this model is quite appropriate.

For somebody who wants a netbook but feels that 10-inch screens are a bit too small, this model is a good option to consider.

We would recommend it for people who just want to use the internet, office suites, standard-res videos and other non-resource-heavy apps.

Just remember that you're paying close to Rs. 5,000 extra for 1.5 inches of extra screen size and one hour more battery life (compared to the 1005HA).

Sony Vaio W Overpriced, but a good netbook

■ Sleek and attractive design, high-resolution screen, comfortable keyboard, fast Wi-Fi 802.11n performance.

■ Expensive, only 2 USB ports.

After its daring attempt with the Vaio P "Lifestyle PC", Sony is using the tried-and-tested netbook formula with this model. The Vaio W is a typical 10-inch netbook. It does maintain Sony's signature style-statement all over; with the Vaio logo atop its glossy covering and the wireless and power switch on the edges. The top fortunately does not attract fingerprints. Overall, look-and-



Sony Vaio W

feel wise, Sony does make a mark. This baby will be noticed wherever you carry it. The build quality is also quite decent. It's fairly light at 1.2 kg and thin enough to be carried around easily.

Opening the lid reveals a 10.1-inch screen bearing a higher-than-usual 1366x768 "HD" resolution. In our opinion, this resolution makes any text content appear a bit too small for convenience. We found it necessary to use a quick fix (a higher font dpi setting) to take care of that. However, we liked watching hi-res 720p videos on this machine. A pebble or segregated-style keyboard, typical of most Sony laptops we see nowadays, is fitted in this one. All keys are sized

well and are really soft to type on, once you get the hang of them.

The touch-pad is also adequately large. The machine comes with the new

Atom N280 processor that offers a minor speed-up compared to the N270. In our battery drain test it touched almost two hours. Thus, one should get roughly three hours of normal usage; this is quite fair for a three-cell battery.

We were also impressed by its transfer speeds using the Wi-Fi 802.11n mode. The Vaio W's only two USB ports might be too few for people who attach a lot of peripherals to their PCs at a time.

Its web cam is accompanied by a nifty app which allows for face detection. This zooms into your face and tracks it even if you change your position. It can also do other cool effects such as face-blurring, eye-mask, warp, etc. Overall, the Sony Vaio W is a good netbook to consider, but it's going to cost you Rs. 30,000. This high-margin price difference between the Vaio W and the others is what we could perhaps call the "Sony tax". We would have gladly recommended this model, had the price been even a rupee below Rs. 25,000.

HOW WE TESTED

- Most netbooks came with Windows XP Home Edition SP3 pre-installed. On those that came with Linux or no OS, XP was installed along with drivers for running the Windows-based benchmark tools.
- All pre-installed software (except for drivers) were un-installed. Automatic updates, remote desktop and system restore were turned off.
- The system was set to "Best appearance" mode. Screensavers were turned off, all power-saving settings were disabled and the screen was bumped to maximum brightness.
- The tests and assessments that we used:
 - Synthetic benchmarks including PCMark05,

3DMark05 and SiSoft Sandra 2008. Other than that, we included a battery of real-world tests to determine the performance of the various components and features of the netbooks.

- Build quality was assessed, included the type of materials used and the sturdiness of the screen hinge.
- Ergonomics, included the usability of the keyboard and touch-pad, also the accessibility of ports.
- The battery life test, using the looped-playback of our test video file with the volume turned to maximum
- The wireless test was performed by directly connecting a Wi-Fi Router to

our test PC. We then paired the netbooks to our router, thus enabling them to access the contents of our Test PC. A 100 MB test file was copied back-and-forth between the netbook and the test PC at two different distances. For the "Short Distance" the netbook was kept next to the router. With "Long Distance", the netbook was at a point outside the test PC's closed room, around 20 metres away.

- The display was tested for brightness and contrast ratio using a Spyder3Elite calibration tool.
- We used DivX Pro v.7.0 to encode our 100 MB test VOB format video file into the DivX format.

MSI Wind Ultra-light netbook with few shortcomings

- Light-weight, bright screen with great contrast.
- No bluetooth, no OS pre-installed, only 80 GB hard disk, low battery life.

The MSI Wind U100 is the first netbook from the MSI stable. The white colour with a minimally-designed top makes it look neat. The build quality is quite decent. It may not be as ultra-thin as the Eee PC 1008HA, but at 1 kg, this is certainly the lightest netbook we have in this test. The keyboard is also quite easy to type on, except for one anomaly. The Fn and Control key on the left corner have interchanged places.